

HIST 380: Cold War Geopolitics and the Nuclear Age

Term: Fall 2026 | Instructor: Prof. George Kennan (gkennan@history.univ.edu)

Course Description & Overview:

Diplomatic and ideological confrontation between superpowers, nuclear deterrence theory, proxy wars, and intelligence operations.

COURSE ASSIGNMENTS & WEIGHT DISTRIBUTION

Assignment Description	Weight	Due Module	Deliverable Format
Primary Source Declassified Cable Analysis	25%	Week 04	Archival Document Analysis
Historiographical Debate Essay	30%	Week 08	Historiographical Critique
Archival Research Monograph	35%	Week 11	Original Archival Paper
Weekly Diplomatic Cable Critique	10%	Continuous	Weekly Document Reflections

WEEKLY TERM SCHEDULE & READING REQUIREMENTS

Timeline	Technical Topic Focus	Assigned Readings & Docs
Week 01	Module 01: Origins of Cold War & Yalta	Gaddis (Ch. 1 & 2); Kennan (Long Telegram)
Week 02	Module 02: Containment Policy & Marshall Plan	Kennan (Mr. X Article, 1947)
Week 03	Module 03: NSC-68 and Militarized Containment	NSC-68 Declassified Whitepaper
Week 04	Module 04: The Korean War & Asian Fronts	Stueck (Ch. 3–5)
Week 05	Module 05: Nuclear Strategy: Deterrence & MAD	Schelling (1960); Wohlstetter (1959)
Week 06	Module 06: Cuban Missile Crisis & Brinkmanship	Allison & Zelikow (1999)
Week 07	Module 07: Decolonization and Proxy Conflicts	Westad (Ch. 3–6)
Week 08	Module 08: The Vietnam War & Quagmire Dynamics	Herring (Ch. 4 & 5)
Week 09	Module 09: Detente & The Helsinki Accords	Sarotte (Ch. 2); Garthoff (1994)
Week 10	Module 10: The Reagan Era & Soviet Stagnation	Zubok (Ch. 8 & 9)
Week 11	Module 11: Berlin Wall Fall & Cold War End	Service (Ch. 14); Final Presentations